hominids like *Homo sapiens* who had adapted to foraging in a waterside environment. At the height of the so-called Last Glacial Maximum some 22,000 years ago sea levels were almost 400 feet (120 metres) lower than they are today.[13] This exposed a broad shelf all the way along the coast of India, most notably off what is now the Gulf of Cambay, where the Narmada and Tapti rivers flow in from the east to debouch into the Arabian Sea – both giving easy access into the interior. Further south this exposed shelf allowed access to the islands of Lanka, Lakshadweep and the Maldives. But ocean levels also rose during the interglacials, so migration along the shorelines would have been in distinct waves, with long gaps in between. Some fifteen thousand years ago a new phase of deglaciation began, with a corresponding rise in sea levels, stabilising some 2500 years ago with our present shorelines.

There is evidence that this rise was accompanied by occasional surges, so-called meltwater pulses when the collapse of ice-sheets released huge amounts of melted ice, resulting in tsunami-like inundations of coastal areas newly colonised by plants, animals and, of course, humans.

There is also general agreement that the massive eruption and fallout from the Mount Toba volcano in Sumatra seventy-four thousand years ago caused an ecological disaster, with thick layers of volcanic ash being deposited all over the whole of South and East Asia. According to one theory, *Homo sapiens* had already begun to move east out of East Africa before the Toba event. The alternative and predominant view is that this migration only began after Toba but then spread very rapidly, enabling the first true humans to reach India by some sixty thousand years ago.

An important contribution to this debate comes from the Jwalapuram site, a dry river-bed with a deep deposit of river sediment in the Jurreru River valley in Kurnool District,